

Restrict Web Access at Work?

Should your staff surf the Web with abandon or should you restrict access to certain sites?

“Any sort of ban... acts as a hindrance”

Sidharth Swarup
CEO, OctaWeb

OctaWebOnline is in the business of focused solutions for the International Casino Industry. It is important for us to allow our team to have access to any and all resources to access relevant information and communicate appropriately to all concerned. Also, we have other businesses which are into mundane Web Development—where too, we have seen that any sort of ban on Web sites acts as a hindrance to productivity. If someone has to waste time or indulge in passing out time, he will do it either ways—through a smoke or a walk in the corridor or office chit-chat. So, why single out Web sites? Just because you have a bad driver doesn't mean that we ban cars on the road!

Yes, it was a move to maintain employee morale as well. Our staff does appreciate the trust relationship they share with the company management and the organisation itself.

We have a high-end radio frequency installed for bandwidth, and as such, we haven't experienced a dramatic downfall in its availability.

I believe banning Web sites is just a means for idle managers to give themselves some task to manage. Banning of content or any service is never an answer to a problem. The perfect or near perfect solution is always simpler. Create harmony in the office environment, recruit mature individuals in your organisation and give them all the freedom in the world: it's that simple. They soar and the organisation soars with them—hand in hand. Thus you create a win-win situation for all involved!

“[ban has] increased productivity”

Prabhakar Sarwade
Corporate Head—Technical Infrastructure Management,
Mahindra British Telecom

Mahindra British Telecom (MBT) as a company is very sensitive towards its customers' need for security and privacy and keeps in mind its employees' interests as well.

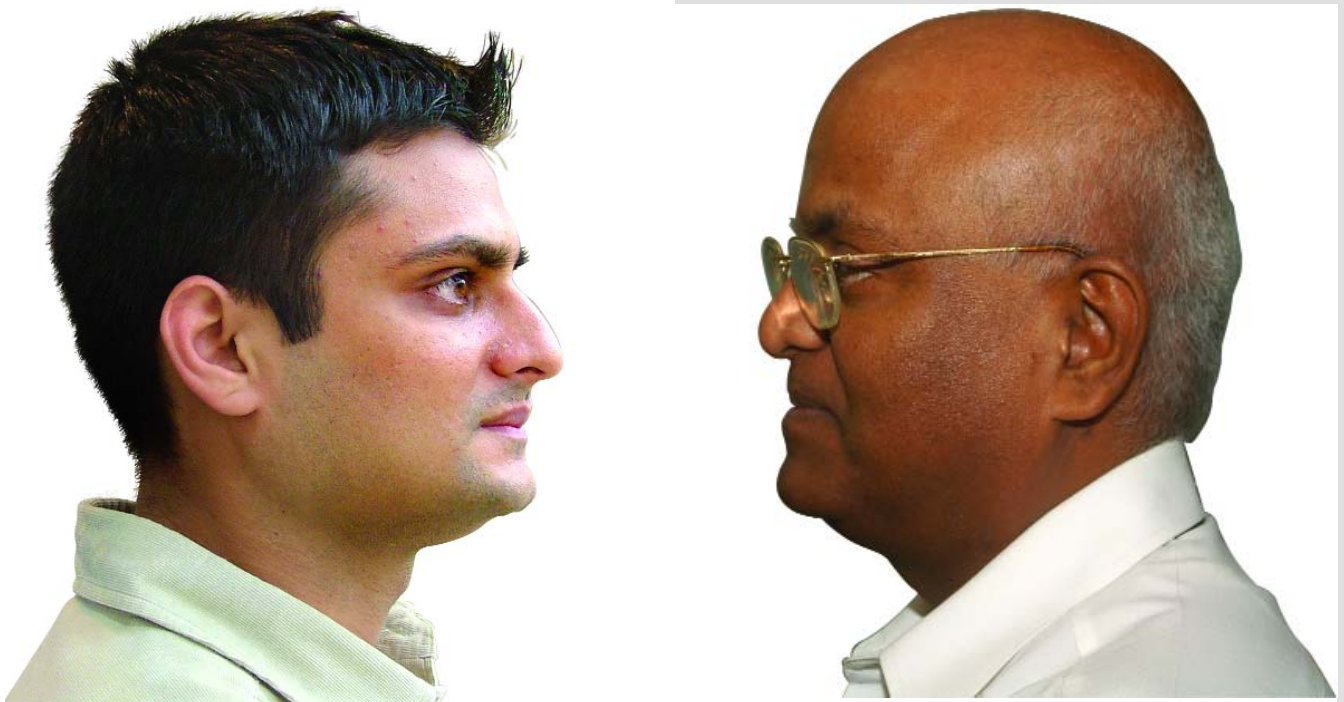
Hence, while we ensure that the working environment is better protected and productive, we also take steps to see that the workplace is one that employees would love to work in.

That said, we decided to deploy Surf Control to effectively control Web surfing. Our staff co-operated at each and every stage of its implementation; they were very professional in their response. This deployment had become necessary as part of the security deployment. Moreover, restricted access was also necessitated by the fact that our project delivery team, which used VPN for access to their projects, was complaining of slow response time.

Post-deployment, there is a remarkable reduction in Internet bandwidth utilisation. Surf Control blocked out Web sites that pertained to glamour, dating, gaming, gambling, etc. Web-based e-mail and chat sites (including MSN messenger) were also in the list of blocked Web access. This has helped MBT in securing the organisation apart from bringing about the much needed increase in productivity.

We have an internal messenger system for employees to connect and interact. We do allow our employees to access Web sites that talk about technology, news, etc., which in effect, does not curb their right to know and be up-to-date.

— As told to Garfield D'Souza



Photograph: Mary Xavier